international career, and well-meaning advice flows from every side. Some say it's my backlift. Some reckon it's my balance. Some say I'm trying to play too many strokes too early in my innings. Becoming increasingly desperate and increasingly confused, in seeking a solution I start to dig in every area of my game, but as I dig the hole just gets deeper and deeper.

'Just take it one ball at a time,' Jonty Rhodes tells me when we meet in Cape Town. It is sound advice.

'Write down on paper how things felt when you were getting runs,' Jacques Rudolph tells me, 'so you can get back into that same mindset when things go badly.' That seems to make sense as well and, alone, I find a piece of paper and write: 'Watch the ball, clear mind, strong feet' … 'Watch the ball, clear mind, strong feet.'

I work hard in practice. I stay positive. I am backing myself and I know I am going to come out on the other side of this bad run and yet, even as I keep smiling, I know I am running out of chances.

Mickey Arthur is the Proteas' coach. He's a good man and an honest man and, on the morning before the first ODI against Pakistan in Centurion, he sits me down and tells me bluntly that I need to score runs if I am going to keep my place and be included in the Proteas squad for the 2007 ICC Cricket World Cup in the West Indies.

With no more credits left, this is the time to deliver, or to disappear.

Mercifully, I find some form, and score 67 in the first ODI at Centurion and 43 in the second ODI at Kingsmead, and then 50 not out at Newlands and 71 not out at the Wanderers. We win the series impressively and, two weeks later, I take my place in the Proteas squad that flies to the Caribbean, determined to win the World Cup, and resolved to set aside our history of misfiring and misfortune in this showpiece event.

I look around the plane. There is no doubt we have the firepower. Graeme Smith, Jacques Kallis, Ashwell Prince, the big-hitting Justin Kemp, Herschelle Gibbs, Mark Boucher and me: it's a fine batting